Bathtime Went From Favorite to Screaming in a Week

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For two years, bathtime was the best part of the day. My daughter would sit in the tub for forty minutes, pouring water from cup to cup, narrating the adventures of a rubber duck with the intensity of a sports commentator. Then one week, out of nowhere, she took one look at the running bath and screamed like the tub was full of spiders.

No warning. No bad experience I could point to. Monday she was a mermaid; Friday she was clinging to the bathroom doorframe yelling “NO BATH” while I stood there holding a towel, completely blindsided.

My first instinct was wrong, and I’ll admit it: I tried to power through. “It’s fine, the water’s warm, look, duckie’s already in!” I lifted her in while she cried. She screamed harder. I kept her in for maybe ninety seconds, the worst ninety seconds of my parenting week, then got her out. She sobbed for twenty minutes afterward. I sat on the closed toilet lid feeling like I’d betrayed her, because I had.

So I stopped. Full stop. For ten days, no baths. Just a warm flannel at the sink, quick and boring, no ceremony. She was filthy in the way only a toddler can be filthy — I found a raisin behind her ear on day six — but the tub stayed empty and nobody cried.

Then I started over, but sideways. I didn’t announce “bathtime is back.” I just ran a shallow bath — barely two inches — while she was playing in the bathroom with me nearby, and put her old toys in it. No pressure to get in. Day one, she stood next to the tub and poured water over the duck’s head with a cup. Day three, she sat on the edge with her feet in, kicking. Day five, she climbed in herself, fully dressed, which I decided to count as a win.

The things that actually helped: new toys, but cheap ones — a set of stacking cups from the pound shop that she hadn't seen before, so the tub had something novel in it. Letting HER do the pouring instead of me pouring water over her. That was the big one. The fear, I think, was about water on her face, about not being in control. When she held the cup, she was the boss of the water. She poured it on her own belly and laughed.

It's been a month now. She does full baths again, though she still announces "no face!" before I rinse her hair, and I respect it completely. We do the flannel for her face. It's fine.

I don't know what caused the fear. Maybe water went up her nose once and her brain filed it under "never again." It doesn't matter. What mattered was that I listened the second time — the time I didn't force it. The tub will wait. They're only scared until they're not, and rushing it just teaches them that bathtime is the place where nobody listens.